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Religion and art in Ashanti

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Document Type: Book Chapter

Original Page: 99

Culture (OWC): [Akan \(FE12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1921-192?

Coverage Date: Not Specified

Place Coverage: Ashanti; Ghana

Section Title(S): X MARRIAGE (Continued)

5. *Quarrelsome nature of the woman.* This is very similar to our own 'incompatibility of temperament' theory, which we find extended to:

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6. *The Mother-in-law.* It is always a temptation to be facetious when we come across the 'mother-in-law' problem cropping up even among semi-civilized peoples. It is possibly a legacy of a yet more remote era when the man, if his clan were of sufficient strength, solved the difficulty of living with the old woman by hitting her over the head with a stone axe. I may be excused my little joke at her expense, because I have never yet had dealings with any primitive people who have not had their own jokes on the subject, unless it happened to be looked upon as no joking matter, which is just another aspect of a similar point of view. The position of these, otherwise estimable, old women in Ashanti, where women are of great importance, and (or perhaps because) matrilineal descent is the rule, seems to lie somewhat midway between these two points of view. There is a well-known saying which when repeated generally causes a sly giggle, ' *ase, fie yenko*', which might be rendered by 'You don't catch us going to mother-in-law's hut'. Another mother-in-law tag runs, 'Be shy', or perhaps our 'fight shy', of your mother-in-law, is nearer to it. Again, there is the following saying, full of sinister meaning, ' *w'ase funu onfere se csi wo a, wo'nso 'onfere se wosum no*' ('If your mother-in-law's corpse is not too shy to knock up against you, do not you be too shy to push it away'). An Ashanti would not ordinarily eat out of the same dish as his mother-in-law. Occasionally one finds sons-in-law going to the opposite extreme, for in my note-book I have the following statement: 'If a man has sexual intercourse with his mother-in-law, *ase*, his wife is taken from him and he is fined double adultery fees.' There is, of course, a great deal more in this

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apparently simple statement than meets the eye. It affords, in fact, a good example of the value of recording all statements of competent informers, even when these appear flatly to contradict each other. At the time this may be somewhat disconcerting, more especially to that rather dangerous type of anthropologist, the man who is out to prove something. In the long run, if one is sure one has obtained the facts correctly, such apparent contradictions may, however, be of very great value. They should always be faithfully  100 recorded, even when they may seem wholly to destroy an argument or theory.

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